

program—that will solve one of the problems.

But the other problem is the program in the server; there is no solution for that. Even if Google releases that as free software, it would not solve this problem. The fact is, if you are using someone else's server, no matter how ethical that someone is, no matter how much you can trust him, you still don't control your computing.

Q What do you say about DRM?

You mean digital restriction management—digital handcuffs? This refers to more malicious features put into some programs to restrict the user, most often to restrict your access to your copies of published works. This is injustice! DRM must not exist. And almost always DRM is imposed by a conspiracy of companies. There are a few exceptions, but they are minor.

Consider, for instance, the inscription on a DVD. That scheme was set up by a group of companies. They established the DVD conspiracy that anybody who wants to make a DVD player has to join them and promise to design DVD players so that they restrict the users, just like every other DVD player manufacturer. Now, I believe that these conspiracies ought to be felonies. So the executives that organised these conspiracies and signed up to participate in it should be prosecuted and imprisoned. But, unfortunately, our governments are sell-outs and they have taken the side of those conspiracies, against the public. These executives are well aware that they are in no danger of being prosecuted.

In fact, many governments have passed laws forbidding us to get around the restrictions they have imposed on us, starting with the US. For instance, there is a free software that can play a DVD and in the US that free software is censored. This shows how evil they are. They actually practice censorship of software. You may ask how I know about these conspiracies. It's because it's no secret—they boast about these conspiracies. They are so confident that they will not be prosecuted for this attack on our freedom and this conspiracy to restrict commerce that they stand upright and say, "We have made this agreement to restrict the public."

So, DRM is evil. We should establish laws to prosecute conspiracies that impose DRM, and we should completely reject all products that have DRM unless we have the free software that can break the digital handcuffs. Never buy an encrypted DVD, or any other product with DRM, unless you personally have the means to break the DRM. If you have a free software program to watch the encrypted DVD, then it is OK to buy an encrypted DVD. But otherwise you must only get unencrypted DVDs. In India, I guess the legal DVDs are encrypted so you should not buy them, and I think the illegal ones may not be encrypted so those are OK.

Q I am excited to know about the status of development of the Hurd?

The Hurd is the GNU kernel that we started in 1990

because there was no free kernel and we needed a kernel to have a complete GNU system. Well, various things went wrong and it works, but it doesn't work all that well. However, it's making progress. A few years ago they could only compile 40 per cent of Debian packages on Debian GNU/Hurd and now they can compile 60 per cent. So, they are making progress, but have a long way to go.

Q Do you have any idea when it will be ready?

No, I have learned not to make predictions about such things. There is a lot of work to be done and progress is being made by volunteers. Now, we don't consider finishing the Hurd as one of the high-priority projects. Although we would like to have Hurd work, but the fact is there are free kernels. So, it is not an area where the community has nothing. The high-priority projects are to do things that free software doesn't do.

Q Linus Torvalds recently criticised you on his blog at torvalds-family.blogspot.com/2008/11/black-and-white.html. Do you have something to say about that?

Well, you can see that he is a person who doesn't believe in freedom. You can tell that from his writings. Why does he reject GPLv3, because GPLv3 protects users from tivoization, which is a fairly new method of denying freedom. It did not exist when I wrote GPLv2 or I would have done something about it then.

Tivoization means delivering a product with some free software, but the machines are designed so that if the user installs a modified version, it won't run at all. So theoretically, the users are free to study and change the source code, but they can't run their own binaries. This means that if they change the source code, it's useless. So practically, they don't have the freedom to study and change the program. Therefore, I decided in GPLv3 to prevent this. V3 requires the manufacturer to provide to the user the information necessary for the user to install his own changed binaries in the product he owns and make it run, assuming it is possible—if it's denied by law, then it's okay, because no one can change that.

We are trying to stop a practice where a manufacturer can change it, but the user can't. Well, this is what Torvalds objects to. He is in favour of tivoization. He doesn't care if the user of, in this case Linux, is free to change it. So, what can we do? He has a right to his views. I am not a one-issue person and I care about a lot of political issues, as you can see if you look at stallman.org. But the free software movement is a one-issue movement. Lots of people support the free software movement, who have different views on other issues. That's why I put my views on other issues into my personal site—they are not part of the free software movement.

Q This whole free software movement has sort of grown bigger than RMS...

I hope so, as I am not going to be around forever.